

no good to pretend there is never anything wrong anywhere, for there is always something—be it big or little—wrong everywhere.

Individuals and civilizations can only strive for perfection.

It is highly unlikely that they will ever achieve it.

Very often it remains for the dissenter to point out that which is wrong. He is a skeptic who doubts, questions and probes—and hence is more likely to recognize lacks, weaknesses and abuses than are his complacent neighbors. The dissenter is also more alert and sensitive to the winds of impending change. He is thus frequently a prophet of the inevitable, who cries for action or change while there is yet time to take action and make changes voluntarily.

Such famed American dissenters of the past as Ida Tarbell, Lincoln Steffens, William Allen White and H. L.

Mencken were labeled muckrakers and much worse by some of their contemporaries. Yet, they were given fair hearing. No one seriously suggested muzzling them. No one felt afraid of being exposed to their views. Their biting commentaries, hard-hitting denunciations and exposes

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helped bring about many needed changes and improvements which even the most antediluvian conservative of today will admit had to be made and, once made, were universally beneficial.

But even if the dissenter is a false prophet and cries of perils or problems which do not really exist, he still performs an important and valuable service to society. He adds spice, spirit and an invigorating quality to life. He may create naught but controversy, but if he is allowed to speak, is heard and answered, he has served to stir the imaginations of others.

Years ago, there were many ruggedly individualistic dissenters on the American scene. They were never hesitant to disagree with minorities or with the majority. They aimed their barbs at vital questions of the day. They